

Incident Alert: 0032. TLP: GREEN.		Date	Breakout Scale
Title	DE	German Doppelganger activity remains on X months after publication 28/11/2024	1

Summary

- A retrospective analysis in August 2024 revealed 666 German posts on X in the period from November 24th 2023 to March 31st 2024 that can be attributed to the Russian influence campaign of Doppelganger.
- The posts consisted of a few lines of text followed by a shortened URL, an image or a video, or a combination of a shortened URL and an image or a video.
- Typical pro-Russian narratives aiming to decrease support for Ukraine and sow distrust in the German government and towards Western alliances can be identified.
- The posts achieved nearly 920.000 views in total by mid-August 2024, according to X data.
- By November 21st 2024, 592 of 666 postings (88,9%) were still available on X.

Incident – When, Who did what, to say what, to whom, why?

From November 24th 2023 to March 31st 2024, inauthentic accounts published 666 German posts matching pro-Russian interests using a similar posting pattern on X (formally Twitter). The posting pattern has repeatedly been attributed to the Russian influence campaign of Doppelganger ([German MFA](#), [CDN](#) & [VIGINUM](#)). The posts consisted of a few lines of text followed by: 1) a shortened URL only, 2) an image only, 3) a video only, 4) a shortened URL and an image, 5) a shortened URL and a video. In the use of images, videos and text phrases, repetition can be observed.

The posts refer to typical pro-Russian narratives including criticism of the German government and support for Ukraine, undermining Western alliances and targeting Ukraine. Economic and social issues (inflation, energy costs, farmers' protests) or fundamentally polarizing topics (migration) are instrumentalized. Support for pro-Russian parties such as AfD and BSW can also be identified.

The retrospective analysis shows a publication peak on March 24th 2024 with 98 posts that day. Due to the unclear number of deleted posts this should be regarded as a snapshot. However, the peak is most likely related to the Crocus City Hall attack on March 22nd 2024. The key narrative that Ukraine and/or the West are responsible for the attack, already identified as a pro-Russian response by [ISD](#), is mainly spread during this period and provides contextual evidence.

The distribution of posts is characterized by the method of amplification, previously attributed to Doppelganger by [DFRLab](#). This means that original posts would each be amplified by accounts sharing them as replies to other users' tweets or replies, resulting in the paradoxical combination of almost no likes and a relatively high number of shares. The posts' interaction stats range from only 0-6 likes while reaching 301-6.078 shares.

Technical evidence provides the typical pattern of 1st level redirector URLs, which has previously been identified by [Qurium](#) and applies to all URLs included in this dataset. A comparison with results by [HarfangLab](#) and [Sekoia](#) revealed that 102 of the 666 posts contain variations of domains previously attributed to Doppelganger.

The method employed to gather the posts relies on a social listening query developed by CeMAS. It focuses on structural attributes while being topic-agnostic and collected German tweets containing links, images or videos, bearing more than 300 shares but less than 100 likes, stemming from authors with less than 100 followers.

The retrospective analysis is based on a dataset that was collected in mid-August. A status check on November 21st 2024 revealed that 592 of 666 posts (88,9%) were still available on X.

Narrative - separate with ;

Meta narratives: Cease Ukraine support; Anti Government

Impact

Reach: According to X data, the 666 posts published between November 24th 2023 and March 31st 2024 achieved

nearly 920.000 views in total by mid-August 2024. Due to the unclear nature of reliability of this metric, this should be regarded as a rough estimate.

Key Objectives and Behaviours (DISARM Red Framework)

- Objective: [Smear](#) - Smear German government and Ukraine.
- Objective: [Cultivate Support for Ally](#): The influence operation is promoting political parties with favorable opinions of Russia.
- [Acquire/Recruit Network](#): Most accounts were previously used for something unrelated.
- [Post Inauthentic Social Media Comment](#): Inauthentic accounts use quote tweets to comment on other users' posts.
- [Conceal Network Identity](#): The X accounts are not revealing that they are part of a larger network, posing as authentic users.
- [Conduct Server Redirect](#): The posts contain redirect URLs to either direct users to operational content if they are the target audience or show them an irrelevant website.

Recommendations and Actions Taken

- The data demonstrates continued presence of Doppelganger content on X, despite its continued use of previously attributed patterns;
- We urge X to take this content down and implement systematic pattern recognition to identify and mitigate similar posts – past, present and future – to protect X users from Doppelgangers illegitimate influence attempts.

Report	Topic	Evidence	Authors	Content type	Platforms
N/A	Ukraine, Anti-Government	Link	Anna Meyer, CeMAS Lea Frühwirth, CeMAS	X posts	X